

Collective Day-Dreaming and the Purchase of Parasocial Romance: A Preliminary Study on Parasocial Intimacy in Otome Game "Cos Weituo" (Cosplay Commission Date)

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Figure 1: Impressions of Cos Weituo (Cosplay Commission Date)

Abstract

The cosplay commission date (Cos Weituo) has become phenomenal with the growing popularity of otome games in China. It represents a unique parasocial intimacy between players and commissioned cosplayers through the embodied portrayal and interaction of fictional characters; this phenomenon combines online-offline fan co-creation, intimacy, and consumption behavior, grounded in players' emotional projections within the female player community. Using auto-ethnography and focus groups, this study explores the mechanisms of parasocial intimacy building in this context, identifying key factors that contribute to or hinder intimacy development during the date. The findings indicate that emotional projection,

character authenticity, interactivity, and physical contact significantly enhance intimacy, while disruptions often stem from communication quality and commercialization balance. Moreover, Cos Weituo intensify emotional fulfillment and immersion, influencing participants' self-expression and social interactions. However, ethical concerns such as emotional exploitation and safety risks also arise. This research contributes to otome game studies and emotional human-computer interaction design by offering theoretical insights and practical implications.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

otome game; parasocial intimacy; cosplay commission; Cos Weituo

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1 Introduction

The otome game market has seen rapid growth in China [14, 23, 25], which has encouraged the rise of various fandom content and consumption behaviors through the integration of emerging technologies and social media platforms [5, 12, 26]. In particular, the offline practice of the otome game cosplay commission date (Cos Weituo) has evolved from a singular activity into a subcultural phenomenon among female players [3, 11, 27]. Cos Weituo is usually a commission that a fan of a virtual character initiates, a one-day date with a cosplayer to cosplay the assigned character. Meanwhile, the client covers all the costs of the date and the cosplayer's remuneration. It enables players to meet and feel their beloved virtual character in real life through interaction with the cosplayer who is costumed like the assigned character, fosters real-world emotional identification, and enhances social bonds among players. However, concerns such as consumerism, overreliance on virtual identities, and psychological pressure to achieve perfect representation highlight the importance of balanced research into both positive outcomes and potential risks.

Current research about Cos Weituo and otome game addresses diverse topics, including propose the notion of a quasi-virtual relationship to conceptualize this emerging form of virtual intimacy [3]. Others have examined how Cos Weituo provides personalized emotional support for clients, functioning as a hybrid offline practice for self-exploration and affective regulation [27]. Or they focus on the game design [14], player behaviors [1, 12], emotional projection [6], and social interactions [5]. Our study contributes by investigating intimacy reproduction mechanisms within the otome game Cos Weituo and its real-world implications. We aim to enrich existing knowledge of mediated intimacy and a form of offline co-creation in the otome game player community, offering valuable insights to game design, culture studies, and emotional design in the HCI field, with data of contemporary female players' mediated emotional needs and experiences.

Specifically, the study investigates:

RQ1, Intimacy construction: How do participants (client and cosplayer) reproduce the intimacy experience from game interaction to Cos Weituo?

RQ2, Influencing Factors: What are the contributors and barriers that affect the intimacy experience?

RQ3, Post-Weituo Impacts: Are there after-effects caused by experiences and memories during the Cos Weituo date that influence the game experience and real life of the participants?

This research aims to explore the parasocial intimacy in the interplay between virtual and real worlds of the otome game Cos Weituo. It offers a fresh perspective on understanding the intricate dynamics of modern fandom culture and emotional consumption. Furthermore, it offers diverse databases and theoretical insights for game design and culture studies, and emotional design in the HCI field that addresses the emotional needs of female users. Designers and researchers in HCI can leverage our work to understand, then design and explore better emotional interaction for female users.

2 Background

2.1 Otome game study

The current researches on otome games primarily focus on several key topics. Firstly, domestic studies are increasingly emphasizing the "female-subjectivity" feminist characteristics in the design of Chinese otome games [13, 14, 25, 26]. These games pay close attention to the emotional needs, psychological expectations, and cultural identity of female players during the design process [4]. The culture of player online communities is another critical area of research in otome games, particularly regarding the emotional support and social interactions among female player groups [12].

Through social media platforms, players share their gaming experiences, discuss storylines, exchange strategies, and spread or create fan works. These interactions not only provide deep emotional connections among players but also contribute to the construction of a unique community culture [12]. Furthermore, the emotional projection of players and the development of parasocial intimacy in otome games have become popular academic topics [8]. In otome games, players often project their emotional needs and idealized views of love onto the game characters, creating a "virtual romance" emotional experience [6]. This emotional projection not only fulfills players' fantasies of romantic emotions but also offers psychological comfort and emotional dependence in the virtual world. This phenomenon highlights the complexity and depth of digital intimacy relationships.

2.2 Parasocial relationship and intimacy in otome game

"Parasocial relationships" describe one-sided emotional bonds audiences form with media figures [10]. Through fictional ways, characters inspire genuine emotional investments from fans, encapsulated in the notion that "the character design is fake, but the relationship is real" [5, 6, 12, 23, 25, 26]. Fans with strong emotional attachments to virtual characters or celebrities are referred to as 'dream girls', a term originating from the Japanese 'yume joshi' [6].

Otome games, in particular, amplify these parasocial interactions, allowing players to "date" characters through immersive, sustained gameplay experiences [5]. The players project real-world romantic and relational needs into these virtual contexts, creating deep emotional intimacy. Unlike real-life exclusivity in romantic relationships, otome players often engage in communal sharing and fan creations, further strengthening their emotional attachments [6, 12]. This concept is increasingly central to digital game research, emphasizing the profound emotional bonds between players and game characters.

2.3 Cosplay, authenticity and cross-gender performativity

Cosplay provides transformative experiences through psychological identification and physical performance [17, 22]. Costumes function as a "second skin," merging identity expression with body control [16]. Successful cosplay involves embodying character traits through gestures and behaviors, enhancing confidence, as well as empowerment [19], similar to "enclothed cognition." Geographic constraints have made Chinese cosplay heavily reliant on

online platforms such as Red Note, Weibo, and Bilibili, emphasizing authenticity, costume quality, and aesthetics [21, 24]. Unique commercial models have transformed cosplay into an industry [17, 20]. Cos Weituo, an offline “fantrepreneur” trend, involves female cosplayers portraying clients’ beloved male characters [22, 27].

Cross-gender cosplay (cross-play) is common among Japanese and Chinese female fans, driven by character appreciation rather than gender identity concerns [7]. This “gender play” aligns with theatrical gender performativity and supports Butler’s concept of gender as fluid and performative [2, 24].

3 Method

Our study conducts an auto-ethnographic approach [18] (n=2) combined with focus group discussions (n=4). First, reflective journals written by two Cos Weituo clients after their respective commissioning experiences were coded to identify six themes: A1, General experience, A2, ‘pi’ (character appearance, verbal and bodily representation), A3, Activity of Cos Weituo (Cosplay Commission Date), A4, Intimate experience, A5, On the edge of virtual and reality, A6, Extension of the date, revealing key elements of intimate experiences from the clients’ perspective. Based on these themes, the researchers designed the interview protocol for the focus group, more details of coding process are provided in appendix 1 and 2. The subsequent two-hour focus group discussion involved 4 participants [9]: 2 Cos Weituo clients and 2 Cos Weituo performers. The participant selection process ensured diversity in their backgrounds and experiences, with all participants having prior involvement in otome games or other female-oriented games, as well as commissioning activities. During the discussion, participants engaged in open-ended conversations based on interview guidelines. The session was fully audio-recorded, transcribed into textual data, and then collaboratively coded on ATLAS.ti, and analyzed by both researchers with thematic analysis.

Table 1: Demographic Information of Interviewees in Focus Group

ID	Age	Gender	Education	Role in Cos Weituo	Experience
P1	32	Female	Postgraduate	Client	2 months
P2	35	Female	Postgraduate	Client	8 months
P3	24	Female	Diploma	Both	18 months
P4	22	Female	Bachelor	Cosplayer	10 months

4 Findings

4.1 To build parasocial intimacy in Cos Weituo

4.1.1 “I saw him standing there”: emotional projection and identification. Clients project their affection toward virtual characters onto commissioned cosplayers, experiencing emotional fulfillment through the characters’ “revival”. P2 emphasized: “*Just a glimpse of him standing there physically is enough. It makes this Cos Weituo date worthwhile, as I usually see him only on screen.*” This physical presence makes characters feel as though they’ve stepped out of the virtual world into reality (P1). However, emotional projection sometimes encounters challenges, especially when meeting for the first time: “*I felt awkward during my first Cos Weituo date. I didn’t know what to say or do because of my inexperience. Although I was happy*

to see my beloved character, knowing it’s another girl beneath the makeup made me anxious about overreacting or offending her”, said P2. Participants view this awkwardness as normal (P3). Communication about shared interests and game experiences helps clients adapt and better recognize the cosplayer as their beloved character: “*Initially, you’re strangers, but you can ‘fake it until you make it.’ It takes time and eventually, you will be comfortable,*” P3 advised.

4.1.2 “Pi (representation) is the most crucial part”: authenticity of the cosplay physical appearance and representation. ‘Pi’, which means skin or surface in Chinese, is a very frequent word during the interview, whenever the topic is related to cosplay, it refers to the authenticity of makeup, costume, and bodily representation. “*we say tie pi (fit the skin) means the cosplayer’s bodily feature (face, body shape and attitude) has a very good match with the game character, shang pi (Skin-on) means we try our best to act like the character, and we try not to do thing that conflict his image, and diao pi (fall off the skin) is I accidentally did something that breaks the image of the character, for example if the cosplayer smoke a cigarette when cosplaying a high school character, that will be very bad and harmful to the client’s emotion, because the character in client’s heart is usually perfect, we won’t do things to break it.*” With very well presented cosplay, not only the client will feel immersed and make believe, but the cosplayer also has strong sense of substitution, “*When I read the hand writing letter from my client, I almost cried, I feel I am the character, and she also feel this way, it is so touched*”, said by P4. But the Weituo cosplayer enhances the authenticity of the character through familiarity with the character’s background and precise performance, making it easier for the client to establish an emotional connection.

Most clients come for good-looking appearance after make up or even before, they feel easily to be immersed and worthwhile spending money for it, “*they(clients) just want a beautiful face to dress up and act like their loved ones (game characters)*”, said by P3.

4.1.3 Contributors and barriers. Proactive interactions and sincere responses during engagements promote emotional exchange between the parties. Facing tasks or experiencing events together (e.g., haunted houses, amusement rides) deepens interaction and fosters a sense of cooperation. Trust and intimacy grow as the client becomes more familiar with the entrusted teacher through repeated engagements.

The barriers to Cos Weituo exist across several dimensions. A key dimension involves the cosplayer’s appearance, as above mentioned ‘pi’. When a weituo cosplayer’s appearance and behaviors significantly deviate from the client’s expectations—failing to adequately “fit the skin”—clients may struggle to fully immerse themselves, negatively impacting their overall experience (P1). Interpersonal dynamics and emotional attitudes also represent critical challenges. If clients are overly reserved or indifferent, it becomes difficult for the cosplayer alone to facilitate engaging interactions, potentially prompting cosplayers to doubt their own performance (P4). Additionally, when the client views the weituo activity as a one-sided commercial service without sufficient respect, the cosplayer may become emotionally detached, further diminishing interaction quality. Maintaining immersion within the commissioned role is equally crucial. If either participant frequently steps out of character to discuss real-life topics, especially when they share few common

interests or conversational topics, the effectiveness of the *weituo* experience diminishes noticeably (P4).

4.2 Impact of *Weituo* Experience on Subsequent Life

The negative impacts of *Cos Weituo* are frequently highlighted in the discussion. During the *Cos Weituo* process, the client experiences intense saccharine-like emotional intimacy, which is ultimately temporary. After the *Cos Weituo* session ends, the client often experiences a more profound sense of emptiness than before. Some clients exhibit signs of frustration as the *Cos Weituo* sessions approach termination, while others find it difficult to accept the ending, becoming tearful when it is time to leave (P4). In addition, the substantial financial costs associated with *Cos Weituo* can lead to feelings of regret and negative attitudes toward gaming activities.

The interviews also highlighted several positive impacts of *Cos Weituo*'s experiences on the intimate relationships of the participants. Participating in *Cos Weituo* sessions improved the caregiving abilities of the cosplayers, enabling them to better support and care for others in daily life (P4). Cosplayers also reported that participating in *Cos Weituo* allowed them to meet diverse individuals, enriching their social interactions and broadening their life experiences (P3, P4).

4.3 Ethical and Privacy

Cos Weituo services present certain ethical and privacy risks that warrant careful consideration. Primarily, both clients and cosplayers must adhere strictly to privacy protocols throughout the service, avoiding the disclosure of personal information, to prevent potential complications arising from blurred personal boundaries. Moreover, emotional detachment following the commission service emerges as a critical concern. Some clients may develop intense emotional projections toward the commissioned cosplayers, struggling to maintain psychological distance afterward. Compounding these concerns, certain problematic client behaviors also pose significant challenges. When dissatisfied, some clients resort to verbally humiliating or insulting cosplayers. Furthermore, driven by possessiveness toward a specific character or cosplayer, some clients find it difficult to accept that a cosplayer provides services to others, potentially escalating to online harassment or cyberbully.

5 Discussion

5.1 The dual construction of parasocial intimacy in otome games and *Cos Weituo*

In otome games, parasocial intimacy emerges from narrative structures and interactive mechanics, such as branching storyline, dialogue options, and personalized interactions. These elements allow players to emotionally connect by projecting ideals onto virtual characters, create their own understanding of the character [6], creating deep but purely parasocial relationships. *Cos Weituo* services extend this intimacy into a hybrid space, blending virtual characters with real-world interactions. Commissioned cosplayers embody fictional characters physically, offering tangible intimacy experiences while maintaining professional boundaries. This unique parasocial interaction acknowledges its temporary and commercial nature.

The interaction between these two forms of intimacy highlights the evolving relationships among young female players.

5.2 Collective dream building between both participants

In cosplay commission services, a unique form of dream building emerges through collaborative performances between clients and cosplayers. Both parties co-create a temporary yet meaningful space of intimacy, acting simultaneously as performers and audience [15]. Cosplayers craft portrayals based on characters' canonical traits and ideal romantic interactions, informed by personal emotions, media influences, and artistic sensibilities. This process aligns the cosplayer's creative vision with the client's expectations.

Notably, this shared fantasy often enriches clients' ongoing relationships with original game characters, integrating tangible memories into their parasocial connections.

5.3 Pay-to-play love game in a safe zone

However, this collective dream-building exists within clear professional boundaries. Both parties maintain an implicit understanding that their performance is temporary and bounded, creating what might be termed a "bounded intimacy" - deep enough to feel authentic, yet structured enough to prevent emotional overflow. This delicate balance allows for meaningful emotional experiences while protecting both participants from potential psychological complications.

6 Conclusion

Otome games, romantic simulations primarily designed for female players, offer immersive emotional experiences. *Cos Weituo* extends these emotions into physical interactions by commissioning cosplayers to embody assigned game characters. This practice creates unique emotional connections between players and cosplayers, reinforcing the players' attachments to characters through tangible experiences. When shared online, these interactions foster collective secondary creations, strengthening the community's shared cultural identity around characters. This phenomenon represents a distinctive form of parasocial intimacy, deepening the mixture of emotions towards a virtual character with the physical world.

7 Limitation and next step

Due to the private nature of *cos weituo*, our preliminary study was very small-scale. We will expand our sample of interviews and conduct in-depth interviews until the findings from this study meet the saturation, to enrich our contribution and framework.

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